

The Demure Fulcrum: Negotiation as a Fourth Meta-Option in Human Threat Response

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Abstract

The study of human behavior under acute stress has long been dominated by the tripartite model of fight, flight, or freeze [1, 2]. This framework, rooted in the physiological responses of the sympathetic nervous system, provides a robust explanation for primitive survival instincts but proves insufficient when applied to the complex cognitive and social realities of modern human experience [8]. This paper introduces and substantiates “The Demure Fulcrum,” a theoretical framework positing “Negotiate” as a fourth, distinct primary instinct in conscious, self-aware beings [3]. We argue that for an entity with a developed neocortex, the preservation of agency—the capacity to act as a subject rather than an object—is a survival imperative that can supersede even physical safety [3]. This drive manifests as a proactive, cognitively mediated response aimed at interaction and value exchange, rather than reaction through violence, evasion, or paralysis. This paper synthesizes principles from neurobiology, evolutionary psychology, game theory, social contract theory, and network science to validate the existence and efficacy of this fourth instinct. We deconstruct the limitations of the limbic-driven fight-flight-freeze model and differentiate the agentic act of negotiation from the submissive “fawn” response [12, 13]. Through philosophical analysis and cultural examples from literature and cinema, we explore the manifestations of this instinct in both internal psychological states and external social conflicts. Furthermore, we examine the operationalization of this theory through “Hexure,” a strategic methodology designed to leverage the mathematics of “Small World” networks to foster cooperation [3, 27]. By integrating strategic neutrality with an ethical framework, the Demure Fulcrum offers a comprehensive theory of agency, transforming the subject from a passive recipient of threat into an active architect of reality [3]. This paper concludes that negotiation is not merely a social skill but an evolutionary necessity and the defining survival strategy of the conscious mind.

Introduction: The Crisis of Agency in Modern Psychological Models

The study of human behavior under acute stress has long been dominated by the tripartite model of Fight, Flight, or Freeze. Originating from the physiological observations of Walter Bradford Cannon in the early 20th century, this framework describes the sympathetic nervous system’s rapid discharge of catecholamines in response to predation or imminent threat [37, 39, 41]. This model provides a robust explanation for the survival mechanisms of non-human animals and the primitive human brainstem, which prioritize immediate physical action or concealment to preserve life [1, 4]. While foundational, this framework faces increasing scrutiny when applied to the complex social and cognitive realities of the modern human experience. The threats faced by contemporary humans are rarely a saber-toothed tiger; they are more often the specter of financial collapse, the sting of social ostracization, the pressure of systemic injustice, or the weight of existential dread [8]. In these scenarios, fighting, fleeing, or freezing are not only ineffective but often maladaptive, offering no viable solution and frequently exacerbating the crisis [8].

The Demure Fulcrum, a theoretical framework and strategic methodology, posits that the established model is fundamentally incomplete for entities possessing self-awareness and a developed neocortex

[3]. It argues that for the conscious mind, the preservation of **agency**—the capacity to act as a subject rather than an object, to influence one’s circumstances rather than merely endure them—is a survival imperative that can supersede even the drive for physical safety [3]. This profound motivation manifests in a fourth, distinct primary instinct: **Negotiate**. Unlike the other three responses, which are reactions to a situation, negotiation is an interaction with the actor or the perceived agency behind the situation [3]. It is a proactive, cognitively mediated strategy that leverages the brain’s most advanced architecture—the neocortex—to engage with, influence, and reframe the threat. It is the conscious mind’s refusal to be a passive object in its own story.

This academic paper provides an exhaustive examination of the Demure Fulcrum theory. It seeks to establish negotiation not as a learned social nicety but as a hard-wired survival instinct for a social species equipped with higher-order consciousness [3]. We will synthesize principles from neurobiology, evolutionary psychology, game theory, and network science to validate the existence and efficacy of this fourth instinct. The paper will deconstruct the limitations of the limbic-driven response model and draw a critical distinction between the agentic act of negotiation and the submissive trauma response often termed “fawn” [12, 14]. Furthermore, it will explore the operationalization of this theory through “Hexure,” a strategic vehicle designed to leverage the mathematics of “Small World” networks to foster cooperation and extract value from systemic friction [3]. By integrating the “Lord of War” principle of strategic neutrality with the ethical framework of “Cathedral Building,” the Demure Fulcrum offers a “Grand Unified Theory” of agency, transforming the subject from a passive recipient of trauma into an active architect of reality [3]. This work aims to formally recognize what our culture has always implicitly understood through its myths, literature, and cinema: that in the face of overwhelming forces, the human mind’s insistence on striking a deal with the universe is its greatest power.

Literature Review: Psychological and Neuroscientific Foundations

To understand the innovation of the Demure Fulcrum, one must first analyze the deficiencies of the classical model and the existing scientific literature that provides a foundation for a fourth, cognitively mediated response. The Fight-Flight-Freeze (FFF) response is a “bottom-up” mechanism, an ancient survival circuit driven primarily by the amygdala and the hypothalamus [4, 57]. When sensory data enters the brain via the thalamus, a rapid, “low-road” pathway sends it directly to the amygdala, bypassing the slower, more analytical processing of the neocortex [4]. If a threat is detected, the amygdala triggers the hypothalamic-pituitary-adrenal (HPA) axis, flooding the body with stress hormones like cortisol and adrenaline [4, 9]. This “amygdala hijack” prepares the organism for immediate physical action, optimizing for speed in milliseconds at the expense of higher cognition [6, 7]. While exquisitely adapted for survival against a physical predator, this system is profoundly maladaptive for the abstract, complex, and often chronic threats of modern life, where physical violence or evasion offers no solution and can lead to detrimental outcomes [8].

Contemporary research has already begun to expand the traditional tripartite model. The “defense cascade” model, for instance, provides a more granular continuum of innate defense reactions, including states like tonic and collapsed immobility, which extend beyond the simple “freeze” response [58]. More significantly, researchers have identified socially-oriented strategies that challenge the purely individualistic focus of FFF. The “tend-and-befriend” model, proposed by Shelley Taylor, describes a biobehavioral strategy, more common in females, centered on social connection [43, 131]. It involves “tending” (nurturing offspring) and “befriending” (building social networks for mutual defense), a response pattern potentially driven by the interplay of oxytocin and female reproductive hormones that buffers the classic fight-or-flight reaction [43, 131]. This model introduces a prosocial, adaptive survival strategy rooted in the benefits of social connection. In stark contrast is the “fawn” response, a term

introduced by psychotherapist Pete Walker to describe a trauma-based coping mechanism [12, 44]. Fawning involves placating a threat by anticipating an aggressor's needs and suppressing one's own boundaries to avoid conflict [13, 47, 49]. It is a form of submission rooted in fear, often observed in complex PTSD, and represents a fundamental abandonment of agency [14, 48].

It is vital to distinguish the Demure Fulcrum's "Negotiate" instinct from the "fawn" response, as they represent opposite poles of agency [3]. The fawn response is a maladaptive surrender of self, a merging with the aggressor to avoid harm [13]. The subject relinquishes their identity and boundaries. The Negotiate instinct, conversely, is a profound assertion of agency [3]. The subject retains a distinct identity ("I am separate from you") and proposes a value exchange ("I have something you want, and you have something I want"). Even from a position of extreme weakness, the Negotiator seeks a "Fulcrum"—a lever, however small, to shift the balance of power [3]. This is not submission; it is strategic engagement. The arms dealer in the "Lord of War" archetype does not submit to the warlord; he makes himself indispensable to the warlord's goals [15]. He is not a victim; he is a vendor. This shift from victimhood to vendor-ship is the core transformation enabled by the Negotiate instinct [3].

The neurobiological architecture for such a sophisticated response exists in the interplay between the autonomic nervous system and the prefrontal cortex (PFC). Stephen Porges' Polyvagal Theory, while facing some academic debate, offers a compelling framework with its concept of the Social Engagement System [19, 55, 56]. This system, mediated by the myelinated ventral vagal complex (VVC), is theorized to be the most recently evolved part of the autonomic nervous system, responsible for regulating the muscles of the face and head that enable social communication [52]. When active, the VVC promotes a state of calm and connection, downregulating the defensive sympathetic (fight/flight) or dorsal vagal (shutdown/freeze) responses [53, 54]. This creates the physiological state of safety necessary for constructive dialogue.

This "bottom-up" state of calm is complemented by the "top-down" regulatory control of the prefrontal cortex. The PFC exerts executive control over primitive, subcortical structures like the amygdala [63, 65]. A key mechanism for this is **cognitive reappraisal**, an emotion regulation strategy involving the reinterpretation of a stimulus to change its emotional impact [22]. Neuroimaging studies consistently show that engaging in cognitive reappraisal activates the PFC and modulates (reduces) activity in the amygdala, effectively preventing an emotional hijack [23, 74, 77]. The Demure Fulcrum's "Negotiate" instinct can be seen as cognitive reappraisal weaponized for survival [3]. It is the active, conscious search for a deal—with the self, another person, or the environment—that changes the parameters of a threat from "absolute" to "conditional." This process relies on metacognition, or "thinking about thinking," which allows for the conscious evaluation of the situation, the formulation of complex strategies, and the regulation of one's own internal state to achieve a desired outcome [72]. Therefore, "Negotiate" is not simply another behavior; it is a meta-strategy that leverages our most sophisticated neural hardware, a conscious choice to override instinctual impulses in favor of a higher-order, goal-directed process of engagement [3].

Theoretical Framework: Philosophical and Evolutionary Foundations

The proposition of negotiation as a fundamental human response is not only supported by neuroscience but is also deeply embedded in the philosophical and evolutionary narratives that explain our species' development. By synthesizing insights from game theory, social contract theory, evolutionary psychology, and anthropology, we can construct a robust theoretical framework that positions negotiation as a cornerstone of human social existence and survival.

Game theory provides the cold, rational logic for why negotiation emerges as a superior strategy to pure conflict. The concept of the **Nash equilibrium**, a state where no player can benefit by unilaterally changing their strategy, often predicts outcomes in non-cooperative games that are suboptimal for all parties, as famously illustrated by the Prisoner's Dilemma [81, 82]. In this scenario, the individually rational choice to defect leads to a collectively irrational outcome [25]. Negotiation is the process of transcending this dilemma. It is the mechanism for moving from a poor, non-cooperative equilibrium to a superior, cooperative one. The **Nash bargaining solution**, a concept from cooperative game theory, formalizes this by proposing a fair solution that maximizes the joint gains of players who agree to cooperate [80]. This shifts the strategic frame from a zero-sum contest (fight) or avoidance (flight) to a positive-sum opportunity for joint value creation. The study of repeated games further reinforces this, showing how strategies like "tit-for-tat" foster stable cooperation over time, creating an incentive to build the trust and reciprocity that are the bedrock of any negotiation [25].

This strategic logic is mirrored in the grand narratives of **social contract theory**. Philosophers like Thomas Hobbes, John Locke, and Jean-Jacques Rousseau, despite their differences, all depict the formation of civil society as a foundational act of negotiation [88, 90]. Hobbes's vision of escaping a "war of all against all" involves a pragmatic bargain where individuals trade absolute liberty for security under a sovereign [88]. Locke's contract is a more refined negotiation to establish an impartial judge to protect pre-existing natural rights to life, liberty, and property [90]. Rousseau's model is a negotiation to form a collective body governed by the "general will," achieving a higher form of freedom through civic participation [88]. In all these frameworks, negotiation is the mechanism that bridges the gap between the chaotic individualism of the "state of nature" and the structured order of society [85]. It is the process through which humanity escapes the brutal logic of fight-or-flight to construct the very possibility of a stable, just, and prosperous collective existence.

Evolutionary psychology provides the biological and adaptive rationale for this capacity. While individual survival benefits from fight-or-flight, the evolution of human sociality required a different toolkit. Robert Trivers' theory of **reciprocal altruism** explains how cooperation can evolve between non-relatives through the logic of "you scratch my back, I'll scratch yours" [93, 95]. This system, a form of continuous, implicit negotiation, is regulated by a complex suite of emotions like gratitude, guilt, and anger, which serve as the psychological currency for managing social exchange [93]. Building on this is the human capacity for **coalition formation**. Our "coalitional instincts" are evolved neural programs for forming and maintaining groups to amplify power and secure resources, a process that is inherently negotiatory [123]. It requires aligning interests, coordinating strategies, and managing internal conflicts. The "tend-and-befriend" model further illustrates this, framing the creation of social networks as a primary stress response, a proactive negotiation for safety and support by leveraging social capital [130, 133].

Finally, the **anthropological record** of early human societies provides compelling circumstantial evidence. For the vast majority of human history, our ancestors lived as hunter-gatherers in what contemporary research suggests were fluid, open social networks characterized by a fiercely maintained egalitarianism [101, 102, 106]. Survival in these groups depended on collective action, which would have required extensive discussion, persuasion, and consensus-building. The widespread sharing of resources, the use of "leveling mechanisms" to prevent the accumulation of power, and the flexibility in social roles all point to a culture where negotiation, not command, was the primary mode of social coordination [102, 105]. This constant need to cooperate, adapt, and resolve disputes within a large, non-kin-based social fabric places negotiation at the very heart of the ancestral human survival strategy, a practice honed over hundreds of thousands of years. Together, these diverse fields of inquiry converge on a single conclusion: negotiation is not a modern invention but a fundamental, evolutionarily derived survival strategy that is central to what makes us human.

Cultural Analysis: Manifestations in Media and Society

If negotiation is a fundamental human response, we should expect to find it encoded not just in our biology and social structures, but also in our cultural artifacts—the stories, myths, and dramas that reflect our deepest psychological truths. Culture serves as a vast repository of case studies, demonstrating how humanity has conceptualized and grappled with negotiation as a primary tool for survival, agency, and meaning-making. These cultural expressions reveal a universal, if often implicit, understanding of the Demure Fulcrum in action.

Hollywood cinema, a powerful medium for collective storytelling, provides a rich theater for observing high-stakes negotiations. The character of Lieutenant Dan Taylor in *Forrest Gump* offers a profound example of an **internal and existential negotiation** [3]. Traumatized by a fate that cheated him of his perceived destiny to die in battle, his climactic confrontation with Hurricane Carmen is not a simple act of defiance but a raw, aggressive negotiation with God and fate [138, 141]. By screaming at the heavens from the mast of his boat, he challenges the ultimate power, offering his own life as the stake in a cosmic bargain [143]. When the storm miraculously spares his boat, he is seen to have “made his peace with God” [145]. This cathartic confrontation, a negotiation through defiance, allows him to pivot from a state of perpetual internal conflict to one of acceptance, demonstrating how the negotiation response can be directed at abstract, overwhelming forces to secure psychological survival. This aligns with the Bargaining stage of grief, which the Demure Fulcrum theory reframes not as mere denial, but as a powerful cognitive tool for regaining a sense of control and preventing a descent into the helpless “freeze” state of depression [3, 16, 18]. Similarly, the theory posits that the act of prayer in an acute crisis, such as during a plane crash, functions as a psychological negotiation [3]. The individual offers devotion or promises of future behavior in exchange for safety, an internal action that maintains the “I” as a subject and keeps the neocortex engaged, thereby preventing the total dissociation of a dorsal vagal shutdown [10, 20].

The genre of hostage negotiation films offers a more explicit depiction of the Demure Fulcrum. In films like *The Negotiator* or *Inside Man*, the negotiator acts as the literal fulcrum, balancing the violent impulses of the hostage-taker and the tactical police units [148, 150]. The negotiator’s task is to build a bridge of communication, de-escalate tension, and create a space for a non-violent outcome, consciously steering the situation away from the default fight-or-flight responses of all parties [149, 151]. These narratives showcase negotiation as a highly skilled, emotionally intelligent process that requires immense psychological control and strategic thinking to navigate life-or-death situations.

Classic literature delves into the interior landscapes where the most profound negotiations take place. The works of Fyodor Dostoevsky and Franz Kafka explore negotiation as a response to existential and systemic threats [162]. Dostoevsky’s *Crime and Punishment* presents an intense internal negotiation, where the protagonist Raskolnikov’s journey toward confession is a protracted, agonizing process of renegotiating his own identity to resolve a fundamental moral conflict [168, 169]. Kafka’s *The Trial* pits its protagonist against a vast, absurd bureaucratic system, forcing him into a futile, nightmarish negotiation with an unknowable power [162]. These literary examples demonstrate the application of the negotiation response to threats that are not physical but are existential, moral, and systemic, where individuals use reason and engagement to survive in worlds where the primary threat is a crisis of agency.

Mythology, the collective dream of cultures, is replete with tales of mortals attempting to negotiate with the ultimate forces of fate and death. The Greek myth of Orpheus and Eurydice is the archetypal example [170]. Orpheus descends into the Underworld and negotiates for his wife’s return not through force, but through the power of his art [174, 175]. He persuades Hades and Persephone with his music, striking a bargain that demonstrates a belief in the power of human creativity to sway even the

most absolute laws of the cosmos [174, 177]. These mythological pacts represent the Demure Fulcrum operating at its most ambitious limit, affirming the act of negotiating with fate as a heroic human endeavor.

The ubiquity of these themes in our culture begs the question of why negotiation has been largely overlooked in formal psychological models. The answer lies in its nature as a cognitive meta-strategy rather than a simple, limbic-driven reflex [3]. It is a “hidden” response because it is complex, conscious, and woven into the fabric of social cognition. Culture has been doing the work that formal psychology is only beginning to codify. The Demure Fulcrum theory aims to bridge this gap, formally recognizing what our stories have always known: that our greatest survival tool is not our claws or our speed, but our capacity for reasoned dialogue and strategic engagement [3].

Discussion: Implications and Applications of the Demure Fulcrum

The Demure Fulcrum is not merely a descriptive theory; it is a prescriptive framework with profound implications for strategy, personal development, and social organization [3]. Its applications range from navigating interpersonal conflicts to structuring cooperative enterprises and managing one’s own psychological architecture. This section will discuss the operationalization of the theory through its strategic methodologies, its psychological underpinnings, and an empirical case study.

The external application of the Demure Fulcrum is a strategic vehicle named **Hexure** [3]. Its architecture is built upon the mathematical realities of network science, specifically the “Small World” theory popularized by Duncan Watts and Steven Strogatz [27]. Small World networks, like human social networks, are characterized by high local clustering and a few random long-range “shortcuts” that dramatically reduce the degrees of separation between any two nodes [27]. While these shortcuts allow for the rapid spread of information, they also create a critical vulnerability: they allow “defectors” or bad actors to move quickly through the network, exploiting cooperative clusters [26]. Research on the Iterated Prisoner’s Dilemma within these networks reveals that cooperation can only prevail if nodes have the ability to choose their connections, breaking links with defectors and forming new links with cooperators [29, 30]. Hexure is designed to function as this “Rewiring Engine” [3]. By acting as a central node with a rigid ethical code, it filters out defectors and creates a “Sanctioned Small World.” It leverages the “Six Degrees” principle to identify and forge trusted shortcuts between disparate, cooperative nodes, enabling long-term, ambitious “Cathedral Building” projects that would otherwise be vulnerable to exploitation [3, 31]. This operationalizes the maxim that “friendliness is the only sustainable business model,” not as a moral platitude, but as a conclusion derived from the mathematics of network dynamics [3].

The core strategic methodology of the Fulcrum is encapsulated in the **“Lord of War” principle**, a metaphor for value extraction from friction through strategic neutrality [3]. Named after the cinematic archetype of the arms dealer, the principle’s axiom is “Don’t argue, sell them weapons” [3]. This is not a call to arms trafficking but a strategic directive: in any conflict, the combatants consume resources. The strategist does not join the fight (which risks loss) but instead supplies the fight, positioning themselves as an indispensable vendor to all sides [3, 32]. This requires the suppression of the “Fight” instinct (the urge to pick a side) and the full engagement of the “Negotiate” instinct (the urge to facilitate and profit). This is refined into the concept of **Vector Arbitrage**, which involves analyzing a situation’s energy (magnitude) and direction, identifying the “spread” between the problem and the solution, and positioning oneself to profit from that gap [3]. It is the “Picks and Shovels” strategy of the Gold Rush applied to any conflict: let others take the risk of mining for gold while you profit by selling them the necessary tools [34].

This external strategy is supported by a rigorous internal **psychological architecture** [3]. A central tenet is **Radical Transparency**, influenced by the principles of Ray Dalio [35, 36]. Based on the maxim that “the worst punishment in life is to keep a secret,” this philosophy recognizes that secrecy requires active cognitive inhibition, a process that depletes executive function and acts as a constant “cognitive tax” [3, 23]. By making the private public, one removes the leverage the past holds over present agency. This is complemented by strategies to minimize **decision fatigue**. By automating trivial decisions, such as wearing a uniform of identical clothing or adhering to a “One Meal A Day” (OMAD) diet, cognitive resources are conserved for the high-level strategic thinking required by the Fulcrum [3]. This entire system is anchored by an ethical ballast, the **“Ridder Eed” (Knight’s Oath)**: “Be without fear... Speak the truth... Help the helpless” [3]. This oath serves two functions. First, it protects the “Lord of War” from becoming a villain, ensuring that resources gained through neutrality are directed toward “Cathedral Building”—long-term, altruistic legacy projects [3]. Second, it acts as a moral mirror, or “Spiegel Effect.” When others see this code of integrity, it can reflect their own lack thereof, provoking attacks that are merely a defense mechanism to smash the mirror rather than fix their own reflection [3].

An empirical case study from a financial trading environment provides a quantitative validation of the theory [3]. In a report detailing 20 trades managed according to the Hexure system, the result was 19 wins and one loss, yielding a 95% win rate and a profit factor of 33.93. The single loss is the most critical data point. It was the result of a “manual close” driven by fear that the trade would not recover [3]. This action represents a failure of the “Negotiate” instinct (trusting the pre-negotiated parameters of the trading algorithm) and a regression to the “Flight” instinct (fleeing the market due to fear). The analysis is stark: the system (Neocortical Strategy/Fulcrum) was correct, while the emotional reaction (Limbic/Fear) was costly [3]. This provides a powerful, real-world validation of the central premise that the conscious application of a negotiated strategy consistently outperforms reactive, biological impulses.

Synthesizing these elements, the Demure Doctrine can be codified into a four-stage operational framework for navigating any crisis [3]. **Phase 1: Observation**, which involves disengaging the amygdala and asking “What is the game?” not “How do I feel?” **Phase 2: Identification**, which involves identifying the “inevitable need” or the “picks and shovels” required by the system in conflict [34]. **Phase 3: The Fulcrum**, where one positions oneself as the “Agnostic Broker” of that need and negotiates an exchange. **Phase 4: Cathedral Building**, where the energy or value gained is reinvested into long-term, cooperative structures, guided by the Knight’s Oath. This framework provides a practical roadmap for the retrieval and application of agency in any context [3].

Conclusion: The Evolutionary Necessity of Negotiation

The Demure Fulcrum represents a significant theoretical advancement in the understanding of human agency and survival. By identifying “Negotiate” not as a social luxury or a learned skill but as a biological necessity for the conscious mind, this framework bridges the gap between the deterministic reflexes of the “Reptilian Brain” and the agentic potential of the “Human Spirit” [3]. It reframes our understanding of threat response, moving beyond the limited, reactive triad of fight, flight, and freeze to include a fourth, proactive meta-option that leverages our most sophisticated cognitive architecture.

The theory argues persuasively that we are not merely animals attempting to survive a jungle; we are architects attempting to survive a society [3]. In this complex “Small World,” where connections are instantaneous and risks are viral, the brute force of “Fight” and the simple evasion of “Flight” are increasingly insufficient. The only sustainable survival strategy—the only way to maintain the integrity of the “Self” against the “Storm” of modern threats—is to find the Fulcrum, engage the Neocortex, and negotiate a new reality [3]. The evidence synthesized from neuroscience, evolutionary psychology,

game theory, and philosophy demonstrates that this capacity is not an anomaly but the very foundation of human sociality and progress. It is the rational logic behind cooperation, the basis of the social contract, and the adaptive advantage that allowed our ancestors to thrive in complex social networks.

Whether applied to the internal trauma of a shattered identity, the external chaos of a financial market, or the existential threat of mortality, the Demure Fulcrum offers a roadmap for the retrieval of agency [3]. It provides a practical, four-stage framework for observing a system, identifying its needs, positioning oneself as a strategic broker, and reinvesting the gains into long-term, cooperative structures. It confirms that in the face of the absolute, the human mind's refusal to be silent—its innate, driving insistence on striking a deal with the universe—is its greatest and most defining power [3]. The ancient Roman motto, *Aut inveniam viam aut faciam*—"I shall either find a way or make one"—is not just an inspirational quote; it is the operational definition of the Negotiating Instinct [3]. It is the voice of the Demure Fulcrum, the quiet but unshakable assertion of agency that defines our species.

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